FILIAL FRICTIONS



On January 13, Makar Sankranti day, Lalu Prasad's estranged elder son **Tej Pratap Yadav,** who was expelled from the RJD in May 2025, visited mother Rabri Devi at her home and invited the family to his ritual *dahi-chura* feast. The next day, Lalu visited Tej Pratap's home, though brother and party chief **Tejashwi Yadav** stayed away. Tej responded with a barb, suggesting that a 'modern-day Jaichand' may have prevented his brother from attending. The fault lines deepened days later, with sister **Rohini Acharya** echoing Tej's thoughts and taking a swipe at Tejashwi.

Delhi vs Dravida Model



Tamil Nadu CM **M.K. Stalin** has done it again. With the BJP-led Centre delaying the announcement of the Sahitya Akademi awards, Stalin has stepped in, declaring a new set of Tamil Nadu–backed national literary honours—the *Semmozhi Ilakkiya Virudhu* (classical language literary awards). In its first avatar, the award will recognise writers from seven non-Hindi Indian languages. It's a familiar script: when Delhi falters/provokes, Stalin converts the situation into an opportunity to underscore the 'Dravidian model'.

THE NEW 'RSS'



Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP) chief and minister in the Yogi government **Om Prakash Rajbhar** has launched his own militia—the Rashtriya Suheldev Sena or RSS! Rajbhar led the first training camp in Azamgarh on January 18, where some 2,500 workers were issued yellow uniforms and long, yellow canes. Party leaders describe the new 'RSS' as a non-political wing, but one with district-level commanders and an ambitious target of 40 volunteers in every village across UP.

By Kaushik Deka with Ashish Misra, Amitabh Srivastava and Kavitha Muralidharan

HEALTH WATCH

INDIA'S WAR ON TB
A NEW, SHORTER-TERM CURE

By **Sonali Acharjee**

Mumbai's tuberculosis programme has reported an encouraging milestone: 89 patients, from the over 1,000 with drug-resistant TB (DR-TB) placed on a new six-month treatment regimen, have been declared cured. For a disease where treatment once stretched to two years, this marks a potentially transformative shift.

The new BPaL-M regimen—a combination of bedaquiline, pretomanid, linezolid and moxifloxacin—condenses treatment to six months, all oral. Early evidence suggests it is shorter, more effective and far easier to tolerate. Mumbai began rolling out BPaL-M over the past year, focusing on eligible DR-TB patients. The initial cure numbers are small but significant:



India carries the world's highest TB burden, and drug-resistant forms represent its most punishing edge. DR-TB develops when the TB bacteria no longer respond to first-line drugs such as rifampicin and isoniazid. Until recently, patients faced 18-24 months of daily pills and painful injections, often with severe side-effects—hearing loss, kidney damage, nausea, depression—and high dropout rates.

they signal that shorter, patient-friendly regimens can work in real-world public health settings.

Wider availability will depend on careful national scale-up over the next few years—training clinicians, monitoring side-effects, and ensuring uninterrupted drug supply. Crucially, experts warn that strict stewardship is essential. Misuse could rapidly erode the effectiveness of these last-line drugs.